

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN JAPAN

Complete Community Opposition How-To

A practical guide for communities facing destructive development projects in Japan, grounded in the environmental-assessment, local-ordinance, and court system and documented residents' movements

This guide uses the Japanese legal terms you will actually encounter (the EIA Law and its assessment documents, the pollution control agreement, administrative vs civil litigation, the information-disclosure law, and so on), each explained in plain language where it first comes up. It describes the national framework; the 47 prefectures and the municipalities each have their own roles and ordinances — check locally.

A note on terms. Important terms are shown in **bold** the first time they appear, with a plain-language explanation right where they come up.

A note on money. Budgets in this guide are in Japanese yen (JPY). Every figure is indicative — Japanese community campaigns range from near-zero (volunteer-run, pro-bono experts, free public data) to funded efforts that commission independent studies. Treat the ranges as a menu, not a bill.

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Community action changes project outcomes in Japan — but the levers are different from most countries, and knowing which ones actually work is half the battle. Japan has a national **Environmental Impact Assessment Law** (環境影響評価法) with public scoping and public comment, but its assessment ends in a "notice," not a hard veto, and — crucially — Japanese courts apply a **narrow test for standing** in administrative cases: to challenge a government approval you generally need a "legally protected individual interest," and residents opposing coal plants and other projects have repeatedly been told they lack it. So the routes that work best in Japan are often *not* the ones that work elsewhere.

What Japan gives communities instead is a distinctive toolkit: strong **local government** power (prefectural governors and municipalities issue many permits and can pass their own, often stricter, **environmental and pollution-control ordinances**); the **pollution control agreement** (公害防止協定) — a binding contract residents and local governments can extract from an operator; the **civil injunction** (差止請求) — a lawsuit against the operator directly, based on personal rights to life, health, and a peaceful living environment, which sidesteps the administrative-standing hurdle; and a deep tradition of **residents' movements** (住民運動) that have blocked and reshaped projects through organised local pressure

since the great pollution struggles of the twentieth century.

Be clear-eyed. The system leans toward development: business and government are closely coordinated, EIA rarely stops a project outright, and the courts are cautious. Communities across Japan — fighting coal plants (Kobe, Yokosuka, Sendai), waste incinerators, dams, landfills, US-base construction (Henoko), and resort and road developments — have organised anyway, and while outright court wins are rare, delay, redesign, binding agreements, and political defeat of projects are not.

What "winning" realistically means. Rarely a court order stopping the project. More often: a stricter assessment or conditions; a binding pollution control agreement; a project delayed for years until its economics or politics collapse; a prefectural governor or mayor persuaded to withhold cooperation; or a redesign that removes the worst harm. Each has happened. The realistic goal is to make the project slow, expensive, and politically costly, and to use the local-government and civil-injunction levers that Japan actually responds to.

The Strategic Framework

Five steps that reinforce each other:

1. **Target identification** — pin down what is proposed, which body decides, under which law or ordinance, and the date the decision becomes final.
2. **Documentation** — build an evidence record strong enough for public comment, a pollution control agreement, and, if needed, a court.
3. **Local opposition** — organise a durable residents' movement, because sustained local pressure is what Japan's system responds to most.
4. **Legal challenges** — use public comment and local ordinances, then the civil injunction and (where standing allows) administrative litigation.
5. **Media strategy** — generate coverage that raises the political cost of approval.

No single step wins alone. The combination — especially local pressure plus the local-government and civil-injunction levers — is what works.

Critical Caveat: A Tilted System Can Make Opposition Harder (But Doesn't Make It Impossible)

Japan's system is tilted toward development, and the narrow standing rule closes the administrative-court door in many cases. Assessing that honestly helps you choose the right tools: when administrative litigation is blocked by standing, the **civil injunction** (which doesn't need administrative standing), the **local ordinance and consent levers**, and **political pressure on the governor or mayor** become the main routes. A tilt changes which lever works; it does not remove them all. Section 10 deals honestly with tilted situations.

How to use this guide

Read Sections 1–3 once. Then work Section 4 (Target Identification) immediately — it produces the facts every other step needs, above all your deadlines and which permits and ordinances apply. Sections 5–8 run in parallel. Sections 9–11 are reference material. Section 12 pulls it onto one timeline; Section 13 helps you decide, honestly, whether and when to keep going.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

Before you can fight a project you have to know who decides it, how, and the words the system uses. Japan is a unitary state with strong local government: power over land and environment is shared between the central government, the 47 **prefectures** (都道府県), and the **municipalities** (市町村 — cities, towns, villages). Most fights turn on the prefecture and municipality, not Tokyo.

The levels of government — and what each one controls

The municipality (市町村). The city, town, or village handles local land-use and building matters, runs many local consultations, and — importantly — can enact its own **environmental and pollution-control ordinances** (条例) that are sometimes stricter than national law. The mayor (市長・町長・村長) and the municipal assembly (議会) are where local

politics is decided, where a project needs practical cooperation, and where a **pollution control agreement** is often signed. A municipality that formally opposes a project, or refuses to cooperate, can stall it even where it cannot legally veto it.

The prefecture (都道府県). The prefectural governor (知事) holds delegated authority to issue many environmental permits (waste facilities, water and air discharge, land development) and accept notifications, and the prefecture can pass its own EIA and pollution ordinances layered on national law. The prefecture also runs the **Prefectural Environmental Pollution Control Council (審議会)** that advises on assessments. For many projects the governor's stance — cooperative or resistant — is decisive, which makes the governor a key political target.

The central government. The **Ministry of the Environment (環境省)** administers the national **EIA Law** and the pollution-control statutes; sector ministries (notably METI, the Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry, for energy) issue the substantive approvals for large projects and hold wide discretion. Regional environment offices of the Ministry operate locally. The national EIA outcome is typically a **Notice of Finalization (確定通知)** rather than a permit that can be simply refused.

Which one is "yours"? Ask: which permit does this project actually need, and who issues it? A waste-disposal or landfill site, a factory discharge, or a land development is usually a **prefectural or municipal permit**; a large power plant runs through **METI** with an EIA; a dam or road may be a public works project of the prefecture or the national government. Pinning this down is Step 1, and it decides the deadlines, the ordinances, and which litigation route is even available.

How a decision is actually made — the journey of a project

For a **Class-1 project** (large projects that must undergo full EIA) or a **Class-2 project** screened into assessment, the EIA path is roughly:

1. **Scoping (方法書).** The proponent (事業者) publishes a scoping document setting out what the assessment will cover. **This is open for public comment** — the first formal opportunity to shape the assessment.
2. **Draft assessment (準備書).** The proponent publishes the draft environmental impact statement, holds explanatory meetings, and — this is your main moment — **opens it for public comment**. The governor and municipalities also give opinions.
3. **Final assessment (評価書).** The proponent revises the assessment in light of comments and opinions and publishes the final EIS.
4. **The approval / Notice of Finalization.** The competent minister or authority reviews the assessment; for a power plant, METI issues its notice. The assessment must be "reflected" in the decision, but the authority keeps wide discretion — this is why EIA rarely stops a project by itself.
5. **The substantive permits.** Separately, the project needs its actual permits — the prefectural or municipal waste, discharge, development, or building permits. **These permits** — not the EIA notice — are often the sharper legal target, and where local ordinances bite.

Beyond EIA, many projects also need to satisfy **local ordinances** and, in practice, to reach a **pollution control agreement** with the local government and affected residents. Those two local levers are frequently more useful to a community than the national EIA.

The rulebook — the policies that decide the outcome

- **The EIA Law and local EIA ordinances.** Was full assessment required and properly done? Did the proponent genuinely address scoping and draft-stage comments? Prefectural/municipal EIA ordinances can set lower thresholds and extra requirements.
- **Pollution-control statutes and ordinances.** Air, water, noise, vibration, offensive-odour, and soil laws — plus stricter local standards a prefecture may set. A project that cannot meet these is vulnerable.
- **Land-use and sectoral law.** City Planning Law zoning, forest, river, nature-conservation, and cultural-property rules each add permits and grounds.
- **The pollution control agreement (公害防止協定).** A contract between the operator and the local government (and sometimes residents) setting binding conditions — monitoring, limits, shutdown triggers, community access. Breach is enforceable as a contract, which can be more practical than public law.

Follow the money — why the system often leans toward "yes"

Understanding the pressures is targeting, not cynicism. Large projects bring investment, construction work, and local tax revenue; energy and infrastructure enjoy strong ministry and business backing; and Japan's close government-business coordination and the wide discretion given to authorities all tilt toward approval. Local governments often want the

investment. None of this is illegal, but it explains the default lean — and why the community's best levers are frequently the *local* ones (ordinances, agreements, the governor's cooperation) and the *civil* route (a rights-based injunction), rather than an administrative-court challenge the standing rule may block.

The overseers — who watches the decision-makers

- **The courts.** Ordinary civil and administrative courts (there is no specialised environment court). They can issue **injunctions** against operators and, where standing exists, **revoke** administrative dispositions — but they are cautious, and administrative standing is narrow.
- **The administrative-appeal system** (Administrative Complaint Review Act) — an internal appeal to the supervising authority before or alongside court.
- **Local assemblies and the audit/ombudsman systems** — including the **residents' audit request and residents' lawsuit** (住民監査請求・住民訴訟), a distinctive route to challenge misuse of local public money.
- **The Board of Audit and prefectural audit commissioners** — for public spending.
- **The prosecutors and police** — for environmental crime and corruption.

Naming the right body in a letter signals you understand the system, and involving the governor or municipal assembly early can change how a project proceeds.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns across documented Japanese and comparable campaigns, not a controlled study. Use them to prioritise effort. The most important lesson for Japan sits inside the table: because administrative-court standing is narrow, the **local-government, agreement, civil-injunction, and political** levers usually carry more weight than a court challenge to the approval itself.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost (JPY)	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	3-4 months	¥50,000-800,000	Project slowed; public better informed
Local opposition only	20-25%	6-18 months	¥100,000-1,500,000	Local pressure; governor/mayor takes notice
Administrative litigation only	10-20%	24-60 months	¥300,000-3,000,000	Slow; often blocked by narrow standing
Civil injunction only	15-25%	18-48 months	¥300,000-3,000,000	Rights-based; no admin-standing hurdle
Media only	10-15%	3-6 months	¥50,000-500,000	Public knows; no action by itself
Docs + local opposition	30-40%	12-18 months	¥300,000-2,000,000	Pressure plus a pollution control agreement
Local opposition + political	35-45%	12-24 months	¥200,000-2,000,000	Governor/mayor withholds cooperation
Docs + civil injunction	25-35%	24-48 months	¥500,000-4,000,000	Stronger, evidence-backed rights case
All steps combined	45-60%	18-48 months	¥1,000,000-8,000,000	Assessment tightened, agreement won, permit refused, delay/redesign, or project withdrawn

Key insight: all steps together are several times more effective than any single one — and in Japan the mix that works leans on **local pressure + local-government levers + a rights-based civil injunction**, not on an administrative-court challenge alone.

A note on legal cost: public comment, the pollution-control-agreement route, information-disclosure requests, and lobbying the governor/assembly are free or low-cost. Litigation (civil injunction or administrative revocation) needs a lawyer and carries filing costs and, if you lose, some cost exposure; environmental and citizens' legal networks and sympathetic bar-association lawyers take some cases at reduced rates. The main unavoidable cost is good expert evidence.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (assessment tightened, agreement won, permit refused, project delayed/redesigned, or withdrawn)

CLEAN-ISH SCENARIO (a cooperative local government):

All steps combined:	45–60%
Local + political:	35–45%
Docs + local:	30–40%
Single step:	5–25%

TILTED SCENARIO (a national-priority project, ministry-backed):

All steps combined:	30–40%
Local + political:	20–30%
Civil injunction:	15–25%
Admin litigation:	5–15% (standing often denied)
Single step:	3–12%

How to read this honestly. In Japan, an administrative-court challenge to the approval is often the *weakest* single lever because standing is denied before the merits are even reached — the Kobe and Yokosuka coal cases show this. The civil injunction (rights-based, against the operator) and the local-government/agreement/political route are where communities have actually moved projects. Even a "loss" that delays a project for years, wins a binding agreement, or turns a governor against it is a real outcome.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **Local opposition** — a durable residents' movement is the engine; Japan's system responds to sustained local pressure.
2. **Documentation** — the raw material for comment, the agreement, the media, and any court case.
3. **The local-government and civil-injunction levers** — ordinances, pollution control agreements, and a rights-based injunction, which sidestep the standing problem.
4. **Public participation (comment)** — cheap, essential, record-building.
5. **Media and political pressure** — the amplifiers that move the governor and assembly.

Winning Japanese campaigns combined a durable residents' movement, a rigorous evidence file, a binding local agreement or a rights-based injunction, sustained media, and political pressure on the governor and mayor — no single track alone.

What Japanese Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur across documented Japanese fights. The coal-plant cases (Kobe, Yokosuka, Sendai) show that administrative litigation alone tends to fail on standing — but that the same movements generated national attention, expert evidence, and political pressure that outlasted the court losses and shaped policy. Long anti-dam, anti-incinerator, and anti-reclamation struggles show that a **binding pollution control agreement** often protects a community more reliably than any judgment, because it is enforceable and specific. Coastal fights show that **fishing cooperatives** and their rights are among the most powerful levers in the country. And repeatedly, the decisive turn is political: a **governor or mayor** who, under sustained organised pressure, withholds cooperation or demands strict conditions. The through-line is that Japan rewards durable, broad, orderly local organising that uses the local and civil levers — not one-off protest and not a lone administrative lawsuit.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

You cannot fight what you have not precisely identified. Answer five questions, and write the answers in a shared document — this becomes the campaign's factual spine.

Core Questions You Must Answer

Question 1: What Exactly Will Be Destroyed?

Get the specifics, not impressions: exact location and footprint, project type and size, what is on the land now (homes, farmland, coast, forest, watercourses, habitat), and what the project would do to it. Obtain the proponent's **assessment documents** (the scoping document, the draft EIS, later the final EIS) — they are public during the EIA, and they are where

the proponent, on the record, describes the impacts and admits the residual ones. List every admitted impact with its page reference — that list is the skeleton of your comments and any injunction.

Question 2: Who Has Decision-Making Power?

Identify precisely: (a) which body runs any **EIA** and issues the notice (the sector ministry such as METI, with the Ministry of the Environment overseeing the EIA framework); (b) which body issues the **substantive permits** (usually the prefectural governor or the municipality — for waste, discharge, development, building); and (c) which **local ordinances** apply. Name the officials and the politics: the governor, the mayor, and the assemblies. Because Japan's live levers are local and political, knowing who the *elected* decision-makers are matters as much as the permitting officials.

Question 3: What Specific Action Stops It?

A project can be stopped or reshaped at several points: refusal of a prefectural/municipal permit; a stricter local ordinance or a binding **pollution control agreement**; a **civil injunction** against the operator; a governor or mayor withholding cooperation; or the project's political defeat. Administrative revocation of the EIA notice is available in theory but often blocked by standing. Map the points and aim at the ones Japan actually responds to.

Question 4: When Is the Decision Final?

Diarise: the **scoping and draft-EIS comment windows** (announced when each document is published); the expected permit dates; the deadline for an **administrative appeal** under the Administrative Complaint Review Act (generally within a set period after you learn of the disposition — check the notice); and the deadline for **administrative litigation** to revoke a disposition (a revocation suit must generally be filed within a limited period — typically six months of knowing of the disposition, with an outer limit — so confirm the exact date the moment a disposition issues). A **civil injunction** can be filed while harm is threatened, but earlier is far stronger.

Question 5: Are There Documented Financial Interests or Systemic Pressures?

Map, factually and carefully: who profits, which companies are behind the proponent, whether land changed hands before the proposal, and whether any decision-maker has a tie to the operator. Use public sources — the corporate registry (法人登記), real-property registry (不動産登記), officials' and politicians' asset and donation disclosures, and public-procurement records. Build a dated, sourced timeline. Keep it rigorous; Section 11 covers doing it safely.

Output of Step 1: a one-page fact sheet with the project's exact description, the permitting bodies and the elected officials, the applicable ordinances, the specific act or lever to pursue, every deadline, and the money map.

Worked example: which lever is actually open

Suppose a waste-incineration facility is proposed near your neighbourhood. Working the questions: **Q1** — the draft EIS admits dioxin and particulate emissions, heavy-truck traffic, and odour. **Q2** — the facility needs a **prefectural waste-disposal permit** (the governor), the municipality runs local consultation and could sign a **pollution control agreement**, and any EIA runs under the prefecture's ordinance. **Q3** — the live levers are the prefectural permit, a binding agreement with strict limits and a shutdown trigger, and, if operation threatens health, a **civil injunction** against the operator; an administrative suit to revoke the permit may founder on standing unless you live close enough to show a "legally protected individual interest." **Q4** — you diarise the comment windows and, once the permit issues, the appeal and revocation-suit clocks. **Q5** — the registry shows the operator's corporate ties and when the land was bought. In an afternoon you know which levers are open — and that the agreement and the civil route, not an administrative challenge, are your strongest cards.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation separates a campaign courts, councils, and the public take seriously from one dismissed as complaint. It is also what a civil injunction lives or dies on, because a rights-based injunction requires concrete proof of threatened harm to health or living environment. Build three layers.

The Three Documentation Layers

LAYER 1: BASELINE CONDITIONS DOCUMENTATION

Prove what exists **before** the project — you cannot show harm without a baseline, and once ground is broken the "before" is gone. Start the day you learn of the project.

Air, water, noise, and odour. Obtain existing monitoring data from the prefecture and municipality (Japan's pollution-control system generates a great deal of it), and record the current condition of your area — air quality, water quality of nearby rivers and coast, ambient noise, and the absence of odour. These four are the classic pollution categories Japanese law and courts recognise, and they are the backbone of both a pollution control agreement and a civil injunction.

Health and living environment. Document the human baseline — nearby homes, schools, hospitals, the age profile of residents, and existing health conditions. Japanese pollution law and the great pollution cases centre on harm to life, health, and a peaceful living environment (受忍限度 — the "tolerable limit" beyond which harm is actionable), so a careful human baseline is directly legally relevant.

Nature and land. Document habitats, protected species, forest, coast, farmland, and cultural properties using prefectural and Ministry of the Environment records. Where a project touches a national park, protected area, or important habitat, note it precisely.

How to hold it. Keep everything dated, sourced, and photographed, in a shared, backed-up folder. A well-organised baseline is more useful than a merely large one. This layer is the foundation everything else stands on.

LAYER 2: IMPACT ANALYSIS

Show what the project would do to that baseline. Your main text is the proponent's **assessment documents** — read them critically and catalogue four things:

1. **Admitted impacts** — every harm the assessment itself concedes, with page references. Unarguable.
2. **Underestimated or omitted impacts** — where the assessment downplays or ignores harm. **Cumulative effects** with existing facilities (a new incinerator or plant added to an already-burdened area) are a common, powerful gap.
3. **Alternatives and the "reflected in the decision" duty** — did the assessment genuinely consider alternatives, and were comments actually reflected? A scoping or draft-stage comment that was ignored is a documented flaw.
4. **The tolerable-limit question** — assemble the facts showing the harm exceeds what residents should have to bear (proximity, intensity, vulnerability of those affected). This is the heart of a civil injunction.

Get expert eyes on it. A critique carries far more weight when a qualified professional — an environmental scientist, physician, or engineer — has reviewed and signed it, even pro bono. Universities, retired professionals, and citizens' science networks are sources of expertise. The goal is a written impact critique that reads as technical, that an authority, a mediator, and a court can act on.

LAYER 3: HEALTH & ECONOMIC IMPACT DOCUMENTATION

Translate environmental harm into human terms, because that is what moves neighbours, assemblies, and reporters. Document:

- **Health** — the specific risks from the project (emissions, dust, odour, noise, water) to nearby residents, drawing on recognised standards and, where possible, a physician's assessment. Japan's pollution history means health arguments carry real weight.
- **Economy and livelihoods** — effects on fishing and farming (fishing-cooperative rights are a distinctive and powerful factor on the coast), tourism, and property values. Quantify it.
- **Community and place** — the loss of a valued landscape, a quiet neighbourhood, or a coastline, and the strain on an ageing community.

Package this layer twice: a rigorous version for comment, the agreement, and any court, and a plain-language one-page version for neighbours and the press.

How to Structure Your Documentation

- **Phase 1: Baseline (Months 1-2)** — assemble the "before" record before ground is broken; request monitoring data early (see the next section).
- **Phase 2: Impact (Months 2-3)** — dissect the assessment; line up expert review before the comment windows so your critique is ready to file.
- **Phase 3: Health/Economic (Months 3-4)** — quantify the human and economic stakes and package them.

Common Documentation Pitfalls (What Fails)

- **Waiting for perfect data** — file comments on time with your best evidence; a strong-enough argument on the deadline beats a perfect one filed late.
- **Only environmental data** — assemblies and courts respond to health, economic, and livelihood arguments too. Breadth wins.
- **No expert review** — an impact critique no qualified person has signed is easy to wave away.
- **Ignoring the proponent's own admissions** — the assessment is a source of concessions. Quote it back, with page numbers.

Documentation Budget Breakdown (JPY)

Item	Low (volunteer/pro-bono)	Higher (commissioned)
Baseline data gathering	¥0-30,000	¥100,000-500,000
Expert technical report (health/air/water/noise)	¥0 (pro bono)	¥200,000-1,500,000
Independent monitoring/measurement	¥0-50,000	¥100,000-800,000
Legal consultation on the file	¥0 (clinic/network)	¥30,000-300,000
Printing/outreach materials	¥10,000-50,000	¥50,000-200,000

Much can be done for near-zero with pro-bono experts and public monitoring data. Spend where a paid report materially strengthens a pollution control agreement or a civil injunction — one solid report on the decisive issue (usually health, air, water, or noise) is worth more than five general ones.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

Most of what wins a case already exists in public records. The job is knowing which record holds which fact, and pulling it before you need it. This section is the shopping list; it also points you to the sources this map links.

Start at the prefecture's and municipality's own websites. In Japan the official documents for a project — the EIA scoping document, the draft and final assessments, the permit notices, and the local ordinances that apply — are published by the prefecture, the municipality, or the proponent, and posted on their websites and public-inspection points. The official documents for local projects (permits, consultations, assembly minutes) live on the **prefectural and municipal sites**; check them regularly. The legal clock often runs from what is posted there.

The assessment documents. Get the proponent's scoping document, draft EIS, and final EIS as each is published — they are public during the EIA, and they are where the proponent admits harm in its own words.

Baseline environmental data. Prefectural and municipal monitoring of air, water, noise, and odour; Ministry of the Environment and prefectural records for protected areas and species; and the proponent's own assessment baseline.

Ownership and money. Company ownership from the corporate registry (法人登記, via the Legal Affairs Bureau); land from the real-property registry (不動産登記); and officials' and politicians' asset and political-donation disclosures.

How to force a document open. A request under the **Act on Access to Information Held by Administrative Organs (1999)** — and the **information-disclosure ordinances (情報公開条例)** that every prefecture and most municipalities have — compels disclosure of records a public body holds. The local ordinances are often the faster route for local documents. Use the wording in Section 8E.

Free and low-cost help. Environmental and citizens' legal networks (such as the Japan Environmental Lawyers Federation, JELF) and sympathetic bar-association lawyers take some of these cases at reduced rates; university clinics and citizens' science groups assist with evidence.

Tie it to the map. The dots and layers here are your starting index — a mapped project points you to the deciding authority, and the local-ally entries point you to the residents' groups, legal networks, and watchdogs already working nearby. Pull that thread first, then follow it into the registries and disclosure requests above.

Where the Japanese Record Lives

Much of the Japanese paper trail is obtainable, and the country's **information-disclosure laws** — national and prefectural (*jōhō kōkai*) — are a central tool: use them to request the assessment documents, the approvals and their

conditions, monitoring data, and the correspondence behind a decision, and treat any refusal as itself reviewable. The **environmental impact assessment file** — the scoping document, the draft and final assessment, and the opinions of the **Minister of the Environment** and the **prefectural governor** — is the spine of the case, and the governor's opinion in particular can supply authoritative reservations you can build on. **Prefectural and municipal assembly records**, ordinances, and any residents'-referendum results document the local position. Company and land facts sit in the commercial and real-property registers. For nature and species, the Ministry of the Environment's designations and Red Data listings establish what is at stake. Where a project involves public money or a public body's decision, the documents underlying that decision are the raw material of a residents' lawsuit. Gather these against the chain of decisions so each document attaches to the stage and the rule it concerns.

Researchers for Hire, and Everyday Research Tools

If digging through corporate filings, agency files and environmental records is beyond a few volunteers, you can hire it out — and this lifts a real weight off novice activists. The field is **opposition research** (or, on the labour side, **corporate-campaign research** — the same methods unions use to expose an employer's finances and record, turned on a developer). For your side, seek **opposition-research firms**, **licensed private investigators** with paid records access, **investigative journalists and freelancers** (often the cheapest, and they publish what they find), **environmental-compliance auditors** to dissect a developer's regulatory record, and **public-records / freedom-of-information specialists** to pry files loose. The investigative tools they use — and that a determined activist can use directly — include **OpenCorporates** and **OCCRP Aleph** (company ownership and cross-border links, worldwide) and **DocumentCloud** (search and OCR large document dumps), with **SEC EDGAR**, **LittleSis** and **MuckRock** as United States examples; most countries have their own equivalents.

For everyday, subject-agnostic research, a small kit goes far: **AI assistants** — Claude.ai, ChatGPT, Google Gemini, and Perplexity for sourced answers — are excellent for explaining a law, summarising a document, or drafting, so long as you **always verify** what they tell you, because they can invent citations; **Google Scholar** and Google's advanced search operators for studies and buried files; and the **Wayback Machine** for pages a developer or agency has quietly deleted.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Critical Insight About Organizing

Sustained, visible, local pressure is the single biggest factor in whether a Japanese project is stopped or reshaped — more so than in many countries, because the administrative-court door is often closed and the levers that remain (the governor's cooperation, a municipal agreement, political defeat of the project) all respond to organised residents. Japan has a deep tradition of **residents' movements** (住民運動): the neighbourhood associations, mothers' groups, fishing cooperatives, and citizens' committees that blocked and reshaped projects from the great pollution struggles onward. Build that kind of movement.

Two principles carry special weight here: **breadth and respectability** (a movement that includes neighbourhood associations (自治会), fishing and farming cooperatives, doctors, and shopkeepers is far harder to dismiss than a small activist core — and in Japan, a broad, orderly, locally-rooted movement is taken more seriously), and **durability** (a campaign that sustains steady pressure for a year or more, through petitions, assembly lobbying, and public meetings, beats one that stages a single protest).

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Months 1-2)

Step 1a: One-on-one conversations. Start with the people most directly affected — neighbours whose homes, health, water, or livelihood is at stake; fishing and farming cooperatives; local businesses. Personal conversations, not mass messages, build a durable core. Listen first: concrete local concerns (a fishing ground, a school's air, an elderly neighbourhood) motivate more than abstractions.

Step 1b: Affinity groups by concern. Let people plug in through what they care about — health, water and fishing, air and odour, traffic safety, landscape. Different concerns reach different neighbours.

Step 1c: Form a residents' group (早めに). Create a **residents' association or citizens' committee** (住民の会・市民の会) with a name, representatives, a simple treasury, and minuted meetings. This is the vehicle for petitions, for signing or demanding a **pollution control agreement**, for negotiating with the municipality, and, if needed, for organising plaintiffs for a civil injunction. Where a **neighbourhood association** (自治会) exists, its formal position carries real weight with local government.

PHASE 2: PUBLIC LAUNCH (Months 2-3)

Step 2a: Community meeting (説明会・集会). Hold a public meeting to inform, gather support, and recruit; bring the maps, the assessment's own admissions, and the comment deadline. Insist the proponent hold its required explanatory meetings, and turn out for them.

Step 2b: Opposition materials. One-page, factual, sourced leaflets; lead with health, water/fishing, and living-environment stakes and the deadline. Include a simple model comment so filing is easy.

Step 2c: Petition and mass comments (署名・意見書). A signature drive (署名) localises and visualises opposition and is a familiar, respected tool in Japan; organise **mass individual comments** (意見書) on the scoping and draft-assessment documents. Many individual comments carry more weight than one letter.

Step 2d: Media at launch. Time it to the comment windows so coverage and the deadline reinforce each other.

PHASE 3: COALITION EXPANSION (Months 3-6)

Step 3a: Organisation outreach. Bring in prefecture-wide and national environmental and citizens' organisations, the local bar association's environmental committee, medical and academic experts, and — crucially on the coast — **fishing cooperatives (漁協)**, whose fishing rights are a distinctive and powerful lever. Each adds credibility, reach, and sometimes lawyers.

Step 3b: Coalition agreements. Agree roles, spokespeople, and messaging clearly before disagreements arise. Who negotiates with the municipality? Who instructs the lawyer? Who speaks to the press? Settling this early prevents the splits that sink movements.

Step 3c: Coordinated public work. Joint comments, joint petitions, shared experts, and shared costs, and a coordinated approach to the governor and assemblies.

PHASE 4: SUSTAINED PRESSURE (Months 6-12)

Step 4a: Assembly and political pressure. Lobby the municipal and prefectural assemblies; seek a formal assembly resolution or opinion against the project; press the mayor and governor to withhold cooperation or demand a strict agreement. In Japan, a governor or mayor turned against a project is often decisive.

Step 4b: Public actions and media (ongoing). Lawful, orderly public meetings, petitions handed over publicly, and steady media keep the issue alive and signal durability. Feed the story new pegs — the assessment, the assembly vote, an agreement demand, a lawsuit.

Step 4c: Prevent failure points. Movements fade when they miss comment windows, rely on sentiment over evidence, splinter, or peak too early. Diarise every deadline, build the file, agree roles, and pace to the decision — which is usually longer than newcomers expect.

Worked example: building a movement that can actually move a project

A coastal town hears that a reclamation-and-power project will fill part of a bay used by the local fishing cooperative. A Facebook group of 2,000 appears overnight — high energy, no leverage. What converts it into force is unglamorous and must happen early. Within the first weeks the organisers do three things. First, they form a named **residents' group** with representatives, minutes, and a small treasury, and they secure a formal position from the **neighbourhood association (自治会)** — which local officials cannot easily ignore. Second, they bring in the **fishing cooperative (漁協)**, whose fishing rights are a distinct legal interest and whose members are directly, individually affected — exactly the kind of plaintiffs a **civil injunction** needs, and exactly the constituency a governor listens to. Third, they line up a physician and a marine scientist to review the assessment, so their comments read as evidence, not sentiment. By the time the draft assessment opens for comment, the movement can file mass comments, hand the governor a signed petition, demand a pollution control agreement, and credibly threaten an injunction with real plaintiffs. None of that required a lawsuit yet — but it made every later lever real. The lesson generalises: **in Japan, the movement you build in month one — broad, orderly, and anchored in directly-affected residents and cooperatives — is what makes the local, political, and civil levers work in month eight.**

Opposition Building Budget: Year-Long Campaign (JPY)

Highly variable. A lean, mostly-volunteer movement runs on **tens to a few hundred thousand yen** (forming the group, printing, petitions, meetings). A campaign expecting litigation should budget for **expert reports (¥200,000-1,500,000)**

and **legal costs (variable; a civil injunction or administrative suit can run into the millions of yen, less with reduced-rate lawyers)**. Japanese movements typically fund the legal stage through **membership dues, donations (カンパ), and coalition cost-sharing**. Keep transparent accounts — it protects credibility.

Hiring Help to Run the Campaign

You need not carry the whole campaign yourselves. A whole industry runs opposition campaigns for hire — the visible turnout at hearings, the public comment, the messaging and the media — known as **grassroots-for-hire** or **public-affairs / grassroots-advocacy** consulting. It usually serves whoever pays, most often the deep-pocketed side, but you can hire the same muscle for yours: **public-interest communications and PR firms, campaign and field-organising firms** that run turnout and canvassing, and, if the fight becomes a local vote, **ballot-measure consultants**. People outside that niche can carry a piece too — a **PR or crisis-communications firm, a campaign consultant, a digital-advocacy shop**, or a seasoned **community organiser** — taking weight off exhausted volunteers who feel they are carrying the opposition alone. Two rules hold. Hire them **transparently**, and never let anyone fake a grassroots front: that is *astroturfing* — dishonest, and ruinous if exposed; the aim is to amplify a real community, not fabricate one. And mind your **setting** — where public campaigning is repressed or dangerous this market may be absent and a visible "show" perilous, so favour trusted journalists and international allies over hired campaigners, and never let paid help expose your people.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Japan gives communities real legal tools, but they are configured differently from most countries, and choosing the right one is essential. Three tracks — participation and local levers, the civil injunction, and administrative litigation.

TRACK 1: PARTICIPATION AND THE LOCAL LEVERS (the front door)

During the EIA, file written **comments (意見書)** on the scoping document and the draft assessment. This is open to anyone and costs nothing: - **It builds the record**. The proponent must take account of comments and, in principle, reflect them; a comment ignored is a documented flaw you can point to later. - **Aim at procedure and substance**. Strong points: inadequate assessment of alternatives; ignored cumulative effects; underestimated health, air, water, noise, or odour impacts; and non-compliance with a stricter **local ordinance**.

Alongside comment, use the two levers that are often stronger than any lawsuit: - **The local ordinance route**. Press the prefecture/municipality to apply — or strengthen — its EIA and pollution ordinances, which can set lower thresholds and firmer conditions than national law. - **The pollution control agreement (公害防止協定)**. Demand a binding agreement between the operator, the local government, and residents, with strict limits, continuous monitoring, community inspection rights, and a **shutdown trigger** if limits are breached. Because it is a contract, breach is enforceable directly — often more practical than public-law remedies.

TRACK 2: THE CIVIL INJUNCTION (差止請求) — the route that sidesteps standing

A **civil injunction** is a lawsuit against the operator directly (not the government), asking the court to stop construction or operation because it threatens residents' rights to life, health, and a peaceful living environment. It is Japan's most important environmental litigation route for communities, because: - **It avoids the administrative-standing problem**. You sue as a person whose rights are threatened, not as a challenger of an administrative disposition — so the narrow "legally protected individual interest" test that sinks administrative cases does not apply the same way. - **It turns on the tolerable limit (受忍限度)**. The court weighs whether the harm exceeds what residents should reasonably have to bear, considering proximity, severity, the area's character, and the project's public value. Your Layer-2 and Layer-3 documentation is exactly what this requires. - **Provisional injunctions (仮処分)** can halt work quickly where irreversible harm is imminent — ask for one where the timeline demands it.

It is slow and evidence-heavy, and outright wins are not common, but it is the route with the fewest doorway barriers and real stopping power.

TRACK 3: ADMINISTRATIVE CHALLENGE (appeal and revocation) — powerful but standing-limited

- **The administrative appeal.** Under the **Administrative Complaint Review Act**, challenge a permit by appealing to the supervising authority (for example, a prefectural waste permit up to the Ministry of the Environment). It is cheaper and faster than court, sometimes a required first step, and puts your arguments on the record.
- **Administrative litigation (行政訴訟).** Under the **Administrative Case Litigation Act**, sue to **revoke** a disposition, **declare it void**, or compel action (mandamus). The obstacle is **standing**: you must show a "legally protected individual interest," and courts have repeatedly denied it to residents (the Kobe and Yokosuka coal cases). Residents living very close, or with a clear individual health interest, have a better chance. **Deadlines are strict** — a revocation suit generally must be filed within a limited period of learning of the disposition (commonly six months, with an outer limit), so confirm the date the moment a disposition issues.

The three legal challenge types

TYPE 1: THE LOCAL / AGREEMENT ROUTE (fastest, cheapest, often most effective)

Local ordinances and a binding pollution control agreement. No standing problem, enforceable, and it delivers the monitoring and shutdown triggers that actually protect a community.

TYPE 2: THE CIVIL INJUNCTION (slower, evidence-heavy, real stopping power)

A rights-based suit against the operator, turning on the tolerable limit. The main court route for communities in Japan.

TYPE 3: ADMINISTRATIVE CHALLENGE (powerful where standing exists)

Appeal and revocation of the permit or EIA disposition — strong when you can establish a legally protected individual interest, often blocked when you cannot.

Legal Strategy Decision Tree

1. **Is a comment window open?** → File comments now; simultaneously push the local ordinance and demand a pollution control agreement.
2. **Is health or living environment concretely threatened?** → Prepare a **civil injunction** (and a provisional injunction if harm is imminent); this avoids the standing hurdle.
3. **Has a permit or disposition issued and do you have a close, individual interest?** → Consider an **administrative appeal** and a **revocation suit** within the deadline.
4. **Project built?** → Enforce the agreement; monitor compliance; use pollution-law enforcement and, for damage, a **compensation suit**.

Litigation Success Factors

A rights-based civil claim by directly affected residents; a rigorous, expert-backed evidence file (especially on the tolerable-limit question); a binding pollution control agreement as a parallel track; strict deadline discipline; and lawyers from an environmental or citizens' legal network. Missing any one weakens the case.

What to Avoid: Legal Failures

Betting everything on an administrative revocation suit that founders on standing; missing the strict revocation-suit deadline; relying on sentiment instead of documented harm to the tolerable-limit standard; and going to court without counsel experienced in environmental litigation.

The Residents' Lawsuit and Revocation Litigation

Two Japanese remedies deserve particular attention. The **residents' lawsuit (*jūmin soshō*)** lets residents challenge unlawful financial acts and certain decisions of a local public body — a powerful and distinctively accessible tool where a project depends on municipal or prefectural spending, a subsidy, a land transfer, or a public contract, because it lets you attack the public underpinning of a private project without needing to prove standing in the ordinary way. **Revocation litigation (*torikeshi soshō*)** challenges the lawfulness of an administrative disposition — an approval, a licence, a permit — and, while Japanese courts are frequently deferential to agencies on technical merits, they will examine whether the procedure was followed, whether the reasoning was adequate, and whether the assessment addressed what the law required. The practical lesson is to build the case on **procedure, reasoning, and participation** rather than on asking a court to second-guess the science, and to check early whether public money or a public decision is involved, because that

is what unlocks the residents' suit. Both remedies have short deadlines, so identify the relevant disposition and diarise the limitation period the moment you learn of it.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence only counts when it is aimed at a specific legal ground. Here is how the records you gathered map onto the arguments that most often work in Japan — so you file the right fact against the right rule.

Harm exceeding the tolerable limit (受忍限度) → civil injunction. The central rights-based ground. Feed it with: proximity, the severity of the health/air/water/noise/odour impact, the vulnerability of those affected, and expert measurement.

A comment ignored, or an inadequate assessment → pressure and, where standing exists, revocation. Feed it with: your dated comments and the assessment's failure to reflect them, plus the assessment's gaps on alternatives and cumulative effects.

Non-compliance with a local ordinance → permit refusal or agreement leverage. Feed it with: the ordinance's stricter standard and the project's inability to meet it.

A pollution control agreement breach → direct enforcement. Feed it with: the agreement's terms and dated evidence of breach — enforceable as a contract, no standing problem.

A permit issued unlawfully, to a resident with a close individual interest → administrative revocation. Feed it with: the specific legal defect and evidence that you live close enough to hold a legally protected interest.

Misuse of local public money on the project → residents' audit request / residents' lawsuit (住民監査請求・住民訴訟). A distinctive route to challenge a local government's spending. Feed it with: the expenditure and the documented irregularity.

The pattern: match one clean, documented fact to one clear ground, and lead with the levers Japan responds to — the tolerable-limit injunction, the ordinance, and the agreement — rather than an administrative challenge the standing rule may block. An environmental legal network can tell you fast which ground is live.

One Fact, Many Arguments

A single documented fact does several jobs at once, and translating it for each audience multiplies its power. Take one finding — that the environmental impact assessment's public-comment step was run so that residents' substantive objections went unaddressed. As a **legal argument**, it is a procedural defect supporting an administrative challenge and, where an approval or licence has issued, **revocation litigation (torikeshi soshō)** — where Japan's courts, though often deferential on the merits, do take procedure and reasoning seriously. As a **residents'-suit argument**, it can support a **residents' lawsuit (jūmin soshō)** challenging the lawfulness of public spending or decisions tied to the project. As a **local-democracy argument**, it strengthens the case for a **local ordinance or a residents' referendum (jūmin tōhyō)**, through which Japanese communities have expressed and hardened opposition. As a **political argument**, it shows the assessment was a formality. As a **media argument**, "they never answered us" is concrete. Going through your strongest facts and asking what each proves to a court, the assembly, the prefectural governor, and a newsroom turns your file into a campaign's argument bank — and in Japan the combination of procedural litigation, the residents' suit, and local-democracy tools has repeatedly outperformed any single channel.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media rarely stops a project by itself, but it raises the political cost of approval, protects the movement, sustains momentum, and reaches experts and allies you would not otherwise find.

How Journalists Actually Work

Reporters need a story with a hook, a human face, a conflict, and a document. Hand them the assessment's own damning admissions (quoted, with page numbers), a named family or fisher whose health or livelihood is at stake, a clear deadline, and a map or striking image. Make it easy, and never give a fact you cannot stand behind.

The Newsworthiness Formula

Local stakes + a credible threat + a deadline + a David-and-Goliath frame + a visual (the threatened coast or neighbourhood, a large signature drive, a packed meeting) = coverage. Japanese project fights — coal plants, incinerators, dams, base construction, fishing-ground reclamation — draw regional and national attention on exactly this formula, especially where health, fishing rights, or an ageing community are at stake.

The framing that travels in Japan: health, fishing, and an ageing community

Some frames resonate more than others in Japan, and using the right one multiplies your coverage and your political weight. **Health** is the strongest: Japan's modern environmental consciousness was forged by the great pollution-disease cases, and a credible claim that a project threatens residents' health — especially children's and the elderly's — carries moral and political force. **Fishing and livelihood** travels on the coast: a threat to a fishing cooperative's grounds is both a legal interest and a resonant story of a community's way of life. And the **ageing, shrinking community** frame — a small town asked to bear a heavy, distant-profit project as its population greys — lands widely in a country acutely aware of rural decline. Find your version of these; they move readers, reporters, and the governor more than an abstract environmental appeal.

Know the Outlets That Cover This Beat

Map the local and regional press (the regional editions of the national dailies, and the local papers), NHK and commercial regional TV, and specialist environmental and citizens' media. Build a contact list with names and beats.

Building Reporter Relationships (The Key)

Give reporters accurate, sourced material and become their reliable local contact. One trusted relationship with a regional journalist beats a dozen cold releases. Offer access — to the site, to affected residents and fishers, to your experts.

Why media matters even when it doesn't make the front page

Coverage does quieter work: it reaches an expert who reviews the assessment for free, a lawyer from a citizens' network, an assembly member who did not grasp how many constituents object, and it creates a dated public record that protects the movement if relations later sour. A steady drumbeat of accurate local coverage moves the governor and assembly more reliably than one national splash.

Sample Media Timeline

Launch with the comment window; refresh at each milestone — the mass comments, the assessment, the assembly vote, the agreement demand, the lawsuit filing, any provisional injunction. Each is a fresh news peg.

Media Measurement

Track coverage, but measure what matters: whether the governor, mayor, and assemblies are responding, whether the movement is growing, whether experts and allies come forward, and whether the politics around the project is shifting.

Amplifying at Scale — Media Help for Hire

Beyond pitching reporters yourselves, you can pay to spread the story at scale — different from a single advert or one call to a local outlet, and available at any reach from local to global. **Public-relations and communications firms** run earned-media campaigns — placing op-eds, orchestrating coverage, staging the media push; for the cause side, public-interest firms such as Fenton, BerlinRosen and M+R work for advocacy groups and unions, not only corporations. **Press-release / newswire distribution services** send a release across a wide network of journalists and outlets — PR Newswire, Business Wire and GlobeNewswire at the global, higher-budget end; EIN Presswire, PRWeb and eReleases far cheaper and nonprofit-friendly, some with cause-specific wires. And **digital and social amplification** shops run targeted paid campaigns and creator partnerships. Two rules: amplify a *true* story from a *real* community — never manufacture fake outrage; and where public visibility is dangerous, favour trusted journalists and international allies over paid amplification.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Ready-to-adapt templates. Keep them factual, dated, and sourced. Submit important ones through the authority's registry or public-inspection process, and keep dated proof of anything you file.

8A. Email to a reporter (story pitch)

Subject: [City]: residents challenge [project] before [deadline] — documents attached

Dear [name],

A [project type] is proposed at [location, prefecture]. The proponent's own draft environmental assessment concedes [specific admitted impact, quoted, with page number]. The public-comment window closes on **[date]**.

A residents' group, **[name]**, representing [number] households and [any coalition partners, e.g. the local fishing cooperative], is filing comments and seeking a pollution control agreement, and has [an expert report / a petition of X signatures]. The human stakes: [health/fishing/living-environment point].

I can connect you with affected residents and our experts, and arrange a site visit. Could we talk this week?

[Name] · [Group] · [phone] · [email]

8B. Letter to a decision-maker (governor / mayor / permitting authority)

Subject: Request regarding [project] — [file/reference]

To [Governor / Mayor / authority]:

We write on behalf of [residents' group] regarding [project] at [location]. We respectfully ask you to **[refuse the permit / apply the prefectural ordinance strictly / require a binding pollution control agreement]** for the following reasons:

1. [Ground 1 — e.g. the assessment underestimates the health/air/water impact on nearby residents.]
2. [Ground 2 — e.g. the project cannot meet the prefecture's stricter [ordinance] standard.]
3. [Ground 3 — e.g. cumulative impact with the existing [facility] was not assessed.]

We request a written response and a meeting. We are at your disposal to provide the underlying evidence.

[Signatories, group, contact]

8C. Public comment (意見書) on the assessment

Public comment on the [scoping document / draft environmental assessment] for [project], published [date]

[Name / residents' group] submits the following comments within the comment period: 1. **Alternatives.** [The assessment does not genuinely consider alternatives, including not proceeding.] 2. **Cumulative impact.** [This project, with the existing [facility], must be assessed together; in isolation it understates the true impact.] 3. **Health and living environment.** [The impact on nearby residents' health and living environment (air/water/noise/odour) is underestimated; documented harm attached.] 4. **Local ordinance.** [The project does not meet the [prefecture/municipality] ordinance standard for [X].]

We request that these comments be reflected in the assessment and that the project be [not approved / subjected to stricter conditions].

[Date, name, contact; attach evidence]

8D. Coalition outreach letter (to an organisation or cooperative)

Subject: Please join the effort on [project] — [area]

Dear [organisation / fishing cooperative / neighbourhood association],

We are a residents' group opposing [project] at [location], which threatens [stakes — e.g. fishing grounds, health, water]. We are building a coalition to file comments, demand a binding pollution control agreement, and prepare a possible civil injunction.

Your [fishing rights / standing in the community / expertise] would strengthen the effort greatly. Could we meet to agree how to work together?

[Name, group, contact]

8E. Information-disclosure request (情報公開請求)

Subject: Request for disclosure of documents concerning [project/site]

To [prefecture / municipality / administrative organ]:

Under the **Act on Access to Information Held by Administrative Organs (1999)** [or the [prefecture/municipality] Information Disclosure Ordinance], we request disclosure of: 1. the full project file and environmental assessment documents for [project]; 2. all permit applications, opinions, and inspection records held; 3. [specific data — air/water/noise monitoring for the site].

Please disclose these within the statutory period. If any part is withheld, please state the specific legal basis.

[Name/group, date, contact]

8F. Legal-action instruction to counsel (civil injunction)

Subject: Civil injunction (差止) against [operator] regarding [project]

To [counsel]:

[Residents' group / named residents] intend to seek an injunction against [operator] to stop [construction/operation of the project], on the ground that it threatens residents' rights to life, health, and a peaceful living environment beyond the tolerable limit. We can provide: proximity and household data, health evidence, and expert measurement of [air/water/noise/odour]. Please advise on a provisional injunction (仮処分) given the [imminent] timeline, and on plaintiffs and costs.

[Date, signature]

8G. Press release (effective)

FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE — [date]

[City] residents submit [number] comments against [project] before [deadline]

[Residents' group] today submitted [number] comments on [project] at [location], citing [top two grounds], and is seeking a binding pollution control agreement. "[Short, human quote from an affected resident or fisher]," said [name, role].

The proponent's own assessment admits [quoted impact]. The [permit] rests with [authority]; the comment window closes on [date].

Contact: [name, phone, email]. Photos, the full comments, and interviews available on request.

8H. Pollution control agreement demand (to the operator and local government)

Subject: Request for a pollution control agreement regarding [project]

To [operator] and [prefecture/municipality]:

We, the residents of [area], request a binding **pollution control agreement (公害防止協定)** covering [project], including: emission and discharge limits stricter than the legal minimum for [pollutants]; continuous monitoring with results disclosed to residents; resident inspection rights; a shutdown trigger if limits are breached; and a compensation mechanism. We request a meeting to negotiate terms.

[Residents' group, date, contact]

Important Caveat

Templates are starting points. Adapt every one to your real facts, cite the actual documents and dates, and — for anything

heading to court — have counsel experienced in environmental litigation review it. Deadlines (especially the revocation-suit period) are strict; keep dated proof of everything you file.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can build a residents' movement or run a multi-year campaign. With an afternoon a week you can still do real damage to a bad project. In rough order of impact for the effort:

1. **Submit a comment (意見書) before the deadline.** One page, in your own words, naming one or two concrete problems (health, water/fishing, the assessment's gaps). It goes on the record and must be taken into account.
2. **Get the assessment and quote its worst admission back to the authority.** The proponent's own words carry the most weight.
3. **Ask the municipality and prefecture to demand a pollution control agreement** with strict limits and a shutdown trigger. One letter can plant this — and an agreement protects the community whether or not the project proceeds.
4. **Send one accurate email to a local reporter** (Section 8A). A single story raises the political cost and can reach a lawyer or expert.
5. **File one information-disclosure request** (Section 8E) — the local ordinance route is fast, and it often surfaces the document that breaks the case.
6. **Tell your ward or neighbourhood association and assembly member** — a formal position from the 自治会 or an assembly member carries real weight with local government.
7. **Tell your neighbours the deadline.** Ten individual comments beat your one.

Do only the first three and you've preserved the record, put a binding-agreement demand on the table, and left a trail others can pick up.

The Fastest High-Value Moves in Japan

If time is short, concentrate on the moves that carry Japanese fights. **File information-disclosure requests now** for the assessment, the approvals, and the monitoring data — they start the record and often expose the gap. **Submit substantive written comments** during any assessment or consultation window before it closes; unanswered substantive objections become a reviewable defect. **Organise the community through its own structures** and reach the local assembly, because a local ordinance or a residents' referendum is a powerful expression of will that officials feel. **Identify whether public money or a public decision is involved**, since that opens the residents' lawsuit (*jūmin soshō*). And **get a lawyer experienced in administrative and revocation litigation** onto the strongest procedural defect early, because deadlines to challenge a decision are short. Do these, and you will have preserved your legal position, started your record, engaged local democracy, and found the channel — procedural litigation, the residents' suit, or the referendum — that fits your project.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Japan's system is tilted toward development, and its narrow administrative-standing rule closes one door before you reach the merits. Being honest about this is how you pick the tools that actually work.

What This Tilt DOES (and DOESN'T DO)

The tilt makes the *administrative-court challenge* weak — standing is often denied, and the EIA ends in a discretionary notice rather than a refusible permit. It does **not** close the other doors: the **civil injunction** (rights-based, no administrative-standing hurdle), the **local ordinance and pollution-control-agreement** levers, the **residents' audit/lawsuit** route for local spending, and **political pressure on the governor and mayor** all remain open, and are exactly where communities have moved projects.

Reading Your Tilt: Cooperative, Mixed, National-Priority

- **Cooperative local government.** A governor or municipality open to residents' concerns. Here, comment, the

ordinance, the agreement, and political pressure do real work.

- **Mixed.** A local government that wants the investment but is sensitive to the politics. Weight shifts toward organised pressure, media, and a credible civil-injunction threat.
- **National-priority project.** A project the central government or a major company is committed to (a large power plant, a base, a strategic road). Assume the administrative route is closed and prepare the **civil injunction, the local levers, and a sustained political and media campaign**; even here, delay and redesign are achievable, and some national-priority projects have been beaten or stalled for years.

Documented Japanese Dynamics

The coal-plant cases (Kobe, Yokosuka, Sendai) show both the wall and the way around it: residents were repeatedly denied administrative standing, yet the fights produced litigation, national attention, and pressure that shaped Japan's coal debate. Long local struggles — over dams, incinerators, reclamation, and base construction — show that organised residents, fishing cooperatives, and political pressure can stall or stop projects the courts would not. The lesson: **when the administrative door is shut, the civil, local, and political doors are where the work happens.**

Assessment Framework — Determine Your Situation

Ask: Is the deciding permit local (better) or a national approval with wide discretion (harder)? Do you have residents close enough for a strong tolerable-limit injunction? Is the governor or mayor persuadable? The answers tell you whether to lead with the agreement/ordinance route, the civil injunction, or a political and media campaign — usually a combination.

Direct Action: Factual Information (Descriptive, Not Prescriptive)

Japanese movements rely mainly on lawful, orderly tools — petitions, public meetings, assembly lobbying, sit-in-style presence at explanatory meetings, and peaceful demonstrations, which are protected. Public assembly can require notification and has limits. Know the law, stay lawful and orderly (orderliness carries weight in Japan), prioritise safety, and get legal advice before anything that could carry legal risk. This guide notes such tactics exist; it does not advise breaking the law, and the movement's credibility is an asset worth protecting.

Honest Assessment

Tilted fights are harder and some are lost. But "harder" is not "hopeless" — the civil injunction, the local levers, and durable political pressure have stalled, reshaped, and defeated projects in Japan, and even an ultimate loss often buys years of delay, a binding agreement, a redesign, and an organised community. Concentrate force where the tilt is weakest — the local and civil routes the standing rule cannot close.

Where Japan's Tilt Shows — and What Still Works

Japan's tilt is subtler than outright repression: it is administrative deference, close ties between ministries, industry, and the bodies that assess projects, and courts reluctant to overturn an agency's judgment on the merits. Large infrastructure and energy projects carry strong bureaucratic and political momentum, and public participation can be treated as a formality. What still works within this is precisely what the deference does not reach: **procedure, reasoning, and disclosure**. A project whose assessment skipped a step, whose public comment went unanswered, or whose disclosures do not withstand an information-disclosure request is exposed on grounds the courts will consider. And where the deference of the national system frustrates a community, **local democracy is the counterweight** — ordinances and residents' referendums have expressed opposition that reshaped or stalled projects, and the residents' lawsuit reaches the public money behind them. The honest frame: outright merits victories are hard, but forcing honest procedure, winning delay and conditions, and mobilising local democratic will are realistic and have repeatedly protected communities.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Most bad decisions are lawful decisions you disagree with. But capture is real, and it looks different in each institution. Read your situation actor by actor — the type of capture changes which lever works, and sometimes tells you a lever is closed. Handle this carefully: the same facts that can sink a project can expose you to a defamation suit if you get them wrong.

Municipal and prefectural officials and assembly members. The most common pressure point: a local government dependent on the project's investment and tax base, or an assembly member with a tie to the operator. Signs: a rushed permit, a sudden zoning change, a consultation that ignores its own record. Lever: the **residents' audit request and residents' lawsuit** (住民監査請求・住民訴訟) can challenge improper local spending on the project, and conflict-of-interest rules can taint a decision — both lower bars than proving bribery.

Permitting authorities. Capture here is usually softer — pressure to approve, or reliance on the proponent's own studies. Signs: an assessment that reads as the operator's document. Lever: comment and, where standing exists, administrative appeal and revocation; and a civil injunction that bypasses the authority entirely.

The operators and their contractors. Watch for land bought quietly before a project is public, opaque shell arrangements, and hospitality or revolving-door ties to officials. The corporate and property registries and donation records surface the timeline a journalist needs. Japan's construction and public-works sectors have a documented history of bid-rigging (談合) — a specific thing to watch and, if evidenced, report.

The courts. Japan's courts are independent and not corrupt, but they are **cautious and deferential**, and the standing rule is a structural barrier, not a bias. Treat this as a design feature to route around (via the civil injunction) rather than misconduct to expose; and seek a provisional injunction where work could start before judgment.

National politicians and ministries. Where a project is a national priority, expect wide discretion exercised in its favour. That is not corruption, but capture of a kind; the honest path is the local and civil levers plus public pressure.

How to act on it, safely. Document from public sources before you speak. Route serious allegations through lawyers and the proper bodies — the prosecutors and police for bribery or bid-rigging, the audit commissioners and Board of Audit for public money, and the residents' audit route for local spending — not social media. A reckless public accusation can expose you to defamation liability and hand the operator a way to change the subject.

Capture, Japanese-Style — and How to Attack It

In Japan, capture more often looks like structural coziness than an envelope of cash: the movement of retired officials into the industries they once regulated (*amakudari*), long-standing ties between a ministry, a utility or contractor, and the bodies that assess a project, and assessments commissioned in ways that make an inconvenient conclusion unlikely. None of this is illegal on its face, which is exactly why it is powerful — and why the attack on it is transparency, not accusation. Use information-disclosure requests to surface who assessed the project, on what terms, and what the internal reasoning was; use the residents' lawsuit to test the public money and decisions that underpin it; and document the pattern factually, letting the coziness speak for itself to the public and the courts. Where genuine unlawfulness — a rigged procurement, a falsified record, an undisclosed conflict — can be shown, the residents' suit and the ordinary courts are open. The lesson is the same as throughout Japan: build on procedure, reasoning, and disclosure, keep the case factual and documented, and let daylight do the work that direct confrontation cannot.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps run in parallel and reinforce each other over a campaign that typically spans a year or more (and litigation, if it comes, much longer). Here is how they fit onto one timeline.

Realistic 12-Month Campaign Timeline

Months 1-2 (Foundation). - Identify the target precisely (Step 1) and write the one-page fact sheet — project, permitting bodies, elected officials, applicable ordinances, the lever to pursue, every deadline. - Form the residents' group and, where it exists, engage the neighbourhood association. - Begin baseline documentation (Step 2, Layer 1) before ground is broken. - Request records via information disclosure. - Start one-on-one organising (Step 3, Phase 1).

Months 2-3 (Launch). - File comments on the scoping and draft-assessment documents — the key participation deadlines — and run a signature drive and mass individual comments (Step 4, Track 1). - Demand a pollution control agreement and press the relevant local ordinance. - Hold the community meeting and launch media timed to the windows (Steps 3 & 5). - Complete the assessment critique with expert help (Step 2, Layer 2).

Months 3-6 (Expansion). - Build the coalition — bring in fishing/farming cooperatives, medical and academic experts, and citizens' legal networks (Step 3, Phase 3). - Finish the health/economic analysis (Step 2, Layer 3). - Assess the civil-injunction route: who are the close, directly affected residents who could be plaintiffs? - Sustain media and begin assembly and political lobbying.

Months 6-12 (Pressure & Decision). - Escalate political pressure on the governor, mayor, and assemblies (Step 3, Phase 4). - When a permit or disposition issues, move fast: consider an administrative appeal, and confirm the strict revocation-suit deadline if you have standing. - Prepare and, if harm is threatened, file the **civil injunction** — with a provisional injunction if work is imminent (Step 4, Track 2).

Beyond 12 months. - Litigation (civil injunction or administrative suit) can run years. - If the project proceeds, enforce the pollution control agreement, monitor compliance, and use pollution-law enforcement and, for damage, a compensation suit. - Keep the residents' group and the file alive; the movement and evidence are assets for the next fight.

Warning Signs — Act Early

The scoping or draft-assessment comment window is open (file now); land is being quietly bought; a national-priority or ministry-backed project is announced; the proponent is holding explanatory meetings. Early action beats late reaction — and organising the pollution-control-agreement demand and the potential injunction plaintiffs early is far stronger than scrambling after a permit issues.

Key Principles (What Separates Winning Campaigns from Losing Ones)

Winning campaigns: identify the live lever (usually local and civil, not administrative); build a broad, orderly, durable residents' movement; document rigorously to the tolerable-limit standard; win a binding pollution control agreement or mount a credible civil injunction; sustain media and political pressure on the governor and mayor; and hit every deadline. Losing campaigns: bet everything on an administrative suit blocked by standing; rely on sentiment; splinter; peak early; or miss the comment and revocation-suit deadlines.

Weaving the Japanese Strands Together

The Japanese strands reinforce one another when run together. **Documentation and information-disclosure requests** feed everything; **substantive assessment comments** create the procedural record; **local-democracy tools** — the assembly, an ordinance, a referendum — build and express community will; **procedural and residents'-suit litigation** creates legal risk and delay; and **media** raises the political cost. A defective assessment step becomes a disclosure request, then a comment on the record, then a ground for revocation litigation; the public money behind the project becomes a residents' suit; the community's will becomes a referendum that shifts the politics the litigation runs alongside. Early on, file the disclosure requests, submit substantive comments before the window closes, and identify whether public money or a public decision is engaged. Through the middle phase, build the coalition, pursue the ordinance or referendum, and prepare the litigation on procedure and reasoning. Sustain all of it, mindful that deadlines are short and the courts reward procedural rigour over merits argument. No single strand tends to win in Japan; woven together, they have delayed, reshaped, and stopped real projects.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

"Winning" in Japan takes several forms, and it is worth naming them so you recognise a win when you get one: - a **binding pollution control agreement** with strict limits, monitoring, and a shutdown trigger; - a **stricter local ordinance** applied, or a **permit refused** by the prefecture/municipality; - a **civil injunction** stopping or limiting construction or operation (rare but powerful), or a **provisional injunction** buying time; - a **governor or mayor withholding cooperation**, or an **assembly turning against the project**; - a project **delayed for years** until its economics or politics collapse, or a **redesign** that removes the worst harm; - or, after operation, **compensation and enforced clean-up**.

Japanese communities have achieved each — usually through organised local pressure plus the local and civil levers, not through an administrative-court win.

Decision Point: Continue, Modify, or Reassess

Reassess honestly at each milestone. If the civil-injunction route is strong (close residents, clear health harm) and the timeline allows, it may be worth it. If administrative standing is plainly absent, do not pour resources into a revocation suit — put them into the agreement, the ordinance, the injunction, and political pressure. If every legal avenue is exhausted,

redirect to compliance monitoring, the next permit stage, or the next election. Continuing is not always right; neither is quitting at the first setback.

The Bottom Line

Japan's system leans toward development and closes the administrative-court door on many residents through a narrow standing rule — but it hands communities a distinctive set of levers that actually work: strong local government and ordinances, the binding pollution control agreement, the rights-based civil injunction that sidesteps standing, the residents' audit and lawsuit for local spending, and a deep tradition of residents' movements. Communities that organise broadly and durably, document to the tolerable-limit standard, use the local and civil levers rather than betting on an administrative challenge, and keep steady political and media pressure on the governor and mayor have stopped, delayed, and reshaped destructive projects — and can again. No single step wins; the combination does. Start today by finding your deadlines, forming your group, and identifying which lever is actually open.